caste lines, especially among first- and second-time voters. "He speaks the language of the youth," says a BJP strategist. "He's modern, rooted and unapologetically ambitious."

There's another vacuum he spots. Bihar's 20 per cent Dalit vote is splintered into numerous sub-communities. The LJP's Paswan base, where Chirag is thought to command en bloc loyalty, has hitherto had a near-autonomous trajectory. The party has not specifically eyed a larger Ambedkarite consolidation, and is thus aloof from other Dalit segments—Ravidas (5.2 per cent), Musahar (3.1 per cent), Panar (1.7 per cent) and Pasi (1 per cent). Chirag has room for growth here. The only other claimant to Bihar's Dalit landscape, Hindustani Awam Morcha leader Jitan Ram Manjhi, is now 80, and his son and heir, Santosh Suman Manjhi, lacks Chirag's panache. They have also not grown much above their Musahar caste band. These dynamics have convinced followers that Chirag could be the one to unite the disparate Dalit flock and claim his father's mantle as Bihar's pre-eminent Dalit leader.

TARGETING NITISH

The timing of Chirag's public rebuke is no accident, say analysts. Nitish's diminishing appeal opens up a vortex of uncertainty, and the LJP chief's advisors perhaps feel it's time to test the waters with the broader electorate that is increasingly frustrated with the security and governance issues facing the state.

Not that the JD(U) is oblivious to Chirag's motives. The critique of Bihar's law and order situation drew an immediate rebuke from the coalition partner. JD(U) spokesperson Neeraj Kumar dismissed the plaints, and also served a reminder: "PM Modi and (Union home minister) Amit Shah trust Nitish Kumar, and NCRB data shows crime has declined in Bihar. Excess of anything is bad...everyone should remember that."

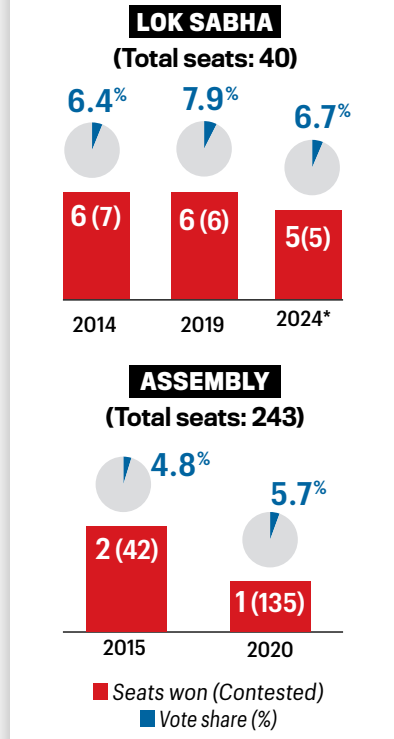
The lessons of the 2020 assembly election still loom large in Bihar's collective memory. When Chirag broke ranks with the NDA and fielded LJP candidates against the JD(U), it may have won just one seat, Matihani, but it polled 5.7 per cent of the vote (238,300-odd votes) across the 135 seats it contested. More to the point, in a remarkable 38 constituencies, the margin of defeat for NDA candidates was less than the votes won by the LJP, enabling the RJD to claim 29 of these seats and the Congress nine.

The fallout was catastrophic for the JD(U), which collapsed to just 43 MLAs in 2020, while the BJP surged to 74 wins. The move was widely interpreted as a spoiler manoeuvre—one that many believe the BJP tacitly encouraged to cut Nitish down to size.

The LJP's performance also throws up intriguing hints. Its 238,300 votes translated to a 10.3 per cent share in the seats it contested. However, discounting the 110 where it forfeited deposits, it narrows the party's real sphere of influence to about 25 seats. These are precisely the constituencies the NDA may deem suitable for any seat-sharing arrangement. Chirag, of course, may not be satisfied with that number.

CONTRASTING FORTUNES

The LJP does stupendously well in LS polls, but performs atrociously in state elections



*LJP (Ram Vilas), party split in 2021

HISTORICAL ECHOES

Chirag's father, Ram Vilas Paswan, once stood poised to become Bihar's kingmaker after the February 2005 assembly election, when the LJP won 29 seats—its best-ever performance in the state. Those results produced a hung house and offered him the power to determine the next government, yet he failed to clinch the moment.

Chirag, sources say, is keenly aware that he cannot afford to miss such opportunities. The strategy, for now, is to be deliberate and daring. The decision to contest from an unreserved seat rather than a Dalit/ reserved constituency—and asking the public to decide which one—signals an ambition to emerge as a pan-Bihar leader. His speeches, peppered with precise criticism of specific incidents, from shocking rapes to police inaction in urban districts, lend his messages moral force. He amplifies these assertions across social media, panchayat meetings and targeted door-to-door campaigns, recasting the LJP's image from a niche caste outfit into a potential kingmaker.

Post-election, a resurgent LJP may reshape Bihar's political equilibrium. Nitish's JD(U) could find its once-formidable coalition position precariously eroded. Caste alliances might shift as other marginalised groups seek their champion. Will Chirag's rhetoric and provocations translate into real seats in the state house? Or will the LJP's historic weakness in local organisation blunt his ascent? As the young politician refines his campaign, balancing his father's legacy with modern aspirations, Bihar watches. One thing is certain: this election will change Chirag Paswan and his LJP forever. ■

—with Anilesh S. Mahajan